LEARN Journal 1 (Due: September 28, 2026)

L – Look Back

- Balancing Systemic Perfectionism with Agile Prototyping

E – Elaborate

- During the third week of my work term, I became deeply immersed in architecting the core simulation engine for our venture, *Chronicles of the Loom*. My primary objective was to implement a 4-layer decoupled architecture that could seamlessly calculate multi-agent social interactions and grudge tracking in real time. Convinced that the foundational architecture had to be completely flawless before writing any gameplay features, I spent over 50 hours designing complex class hierarchies and edge-case error handlers. By the end of the sprint, I had accumulated hundreds of lines of abstract framework code, but not a single playable tavern scenario to showcase during our weekly progress review with my Seneca HELIX venture advisor. When asked to demonstrate a working build where NPCs made observable decisions, I could only show console debug logs. My advisor noted that while the underlying logic was theoretically sound, spending weeks on theoretical scalability without a demonstrable proof-of-concept left our milestone deliverables vulnerable to significant delays.

A – Analyze

- I allowed my desire for engineering perfection to override agile delivery principles. Coming from an academic programming background, I fell into the trap of over-engineering solutions for problems our prototype did not yet face. By isolating myself in backend abstractions and failing to build incremental, demonstrable features, I neglected the primary goal of an early-stage work term: rapid, user-facing validation. This lack of prioritization created unnecessary pressure and stalled interdisciplinary progress.

R – Revised Approach

- Going forward, I will adopt a strict "Minimum Viable System" approach for all development sprints. I will define clear sprint acceptance criteria centered on playable, testable interactions rather than theoretical code completeness. I will time-box architectural design to the first two days of a sprint and dedicate the remainder to concrete feature implementation, testing, and stakeholder-ready demonstrations.

N – New Perspective

- My key takeaway from this experience is that working software is the primary measure of progress. Elegant code is meaningless if it cannot be interacted with, tested, and validated by users and supervisors. Maintaining momentum through smaller, functional milestones builds far more stakeholder trust and long-term product stability than delayed perfectionism.